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POLITICS

Jai Bhim Kunj

On two kinds of hijacking — the demolition of Jai Bhim Nagar in Mumbai's Hiranandani complex, and the suppression of Dalit and working-class voices within Delhi's 'apolitical' Reclaim the Night protests. An editorial on who gets to own a movement's grief, and what solidarity means when it is curated.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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ABOUT

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How Hiranandani and Jai Bhim Nagar's Case is Quietly Mirrored in the 'Apolitical Reclaim the Night's of Gentrified New Delhi, & There is More Than One Way to Hijack a Protest

19th August 2024: There's a poem by Amrita Pritam called 'Hear-Say' that goes a little something like this: there's a game of two chits - one of them reads 'Hear' and the other reads, 'Say'. Every round, He and She take their picks, and do as their chits demand. Every round, by fate or coincidence, She picks, 'Hear', and does as she is told. The King tells her, 'Drink poison'. Meera becomes She. The Saint tells her, 'Turn to stone'. Ahalya becomes She. The Lord tells her, 'Get out'. Sita becomes She. Through pyres, she cannot scream. Through divorce, she grits her teeth. The chit that reads 'Hear' never does land His way.

The first time I heard this poem was three days ago on the footpath outside Vasant Square Mall on the 16th night of August 2024, in the voice of a child not a day older than 14, protesting rape.

Vasant Kunj's 'Reclaim the Night' was one of the countless spontaneous protests held across the country since the eve of India's 78th Independence Day, when the outrage against the horrific rape and murder of a 31-year-old doctor in Kolkata five days prior turned international. Protest coordinator and trade union activist Arundhati, upon being asked precisely what *kind of* protest it was, uttered a sentence that will come to serve as a *mise en place* for the remainder of this story: "It is a citizen's protest, organised by the residents of Vasant Kunj."

And so it was.

Despite being held at Vasant Square Mall, an affluent locality of Vasant Kunj Sector-B, the demonstration had been organized – purposefully and significantly – by the local domestic workers' union: SGU (Sangrami Gharelu Kamgaar Union), Collective Delhi, and residents of the Harijan Basti the same distance from the mall as the upper-class B2 gated-community.

The palpably apolitical nature of the protest despite its organisation by a political group is noteworthy, not least because the residents of the Harijan Basti and B2 Residents' Welfare Association have a history of conflict rich enough to rival Powai. In light of the recent media attention garnered by the vocal and insulting exclusion of Jai Bhim Nagar ex-residents by Hiranandani residents at what they proclaimed was exclusively their 'reclaim the night' protest, there has formed conspicuous and necessary room in the nationwide antirape sentiment gaining steam right now for an acknowledgment that caste-based violence – just like sexual violence – does not emerge from vacuum. Both grow progressively, & passively, in environments that foster prejudice, microaggressions, and systemic dehumanisation; the languages and cultures of hegemony – all of which were enthusiastically present at the gathering on 16th August, 2024. If only one were willing to look.

8:15 | Kalpana

The WhatsApp forward circulated the same morning states that the protest starts at 8:30 PM outside Vasant Square Mall. By 8:15, people begin to arrive. Many wander into the fire assembly area in front of the mall building, wondering where everyone's supposed to meet. They don't know that the protest isn't meant to happen up there in front of the kiddie rides and KFC, but down on the road, where everyone can see.



Com. Shreya, a seasoned activist and the anchor of this protest, runs back and forth between the two places, waiting for wanderers at the stairs of the mall, nudging them in the right direction. Shreya doesn't think there was any (noteworthy)

In the end, she reads the whole thing off a phone. *'Hear-Say'* by Amrita Pritam, rushed and unintonated like only an eighth grader can manage. She doesn't bother sticking around for praise.



(PHOTOGRAPH VIA COLLECTIVE, BY AKSHAY)

8:30 | Class Clown

By 8:30, the crowd in front of VSM organise themselves the way members of any civil society will do without external interference: into cliques. Looking up at them from the elevated rails of the mall, they look a bit the way oil does over water. Bound clusters with space in between.

A few minutes ago, these groups didn't exist. It's natural to fall into them once they form; every time new participants arrive, typically with a few members of the family, they scan the crowd for people they recognise, and assimilate. But fifteen minutes ago there weren't enough heads around for one to even look for familiar faces. Fifteen minutes ago, everyone was a straggler.

Back towards the staircase is a small group of mostly women in pajama t-shirts and cotton kurtis who talk in English and seem to know each other. Since I was there early, most of them first came to me, asking who the organiser was. Every single time, I'd point them toward the activists and Union members I'd already spoken to. And every single time, they'd lose interest.

On the other side is the much larger group of mostly Bengali women with their heads covered with *aanchals* or *dupattas* to pair with their salwar-kameez (except one who shows up in a nightie. She jokes about it ('I just came here in a nightie.') but no one laughs, and it becomes clear that these women aren't just neighbors but friends). The activists are attached to this group, but they keep themselves busy with pleasantries and inventory. Scattered between the two are the true stragglers: a young man nursing the straps of his backpack. An antisocial doctor who doesn't know what to do with herself. A journalist lugging around a camera that's dead.

Soon, it's decided that sufficient people have shown up to begin. Shreya joins us from her designated position at the base of the stairs and takes charge. Her directions are clear and unambiguous, and the team works fast. Candles and posters are distributed to those who haven't brought them, and people are asked to arrange themselves in a semicircle formation – SGU members in the front row. Beside me, Nightie Lady jokes that she can't be expected to hold her candle *and* her poster at the same time (something something flammable materials, something something all the work around this house). When she sees me smile, she holds the paper against her stomach as if trying to fix it there (it reads, "Fight on, RG Kar! We are with you!") and raises her eyebrows. I wonder if the four upper-class women still standing at the very front of the formation are going to move. They aren't.

I raise my eyebrows back.

9:00 | Anita

Shreya's voice is as powerful as it is raw, like everyone who has a habit of raising it, more often than not literally. As she briefs us about the case, the plan, and the point of the gathering, she also tells us we'll have to make do without mics. The RWA has denied permission to use speakers.



(SHREYA ADDRESSING THE GATHERING, VIA SGU BY GOWRI)

"It was a deliberate choice to do this outside a mall," Shreya tells us. "It was a deliberate choice to do it in a public space, here. It isn't often you'll see this kind of thing happening in a place like this. Many of you must work in offices. Many in your homes, many in other people's homes. In many ways, this is a gathering of the working women of Vasant Kunj."

She says it with a smile, like there's a joke in there I'm not in on. I am in on it, though. The oil spill had cross-contamination. I'd seen one of the women from the RWA group walk over and extricate one of the SGU members to bring her back into hers and introduce her to everyone. An ex-employee. *'Do you recognise Didi? She took care of you when you were*



(CANDLEHOLDERS, PHOTOGRAPH VIA SGU BY GOWRI)

"In this country, they say that a woman is equal to a man. Is she?" Com. Anita's speech is a good one to open with. "They say that we are free. Are we?" I struggle to start the recorder with one hand curled around the flame, protecting it. "How can we be free if we don't have the freedom to go out and earn a penny for the house? How can we be free if we can't read?" Beside me, the RWA gang have all brought candles that come in little transparent holders, the kind that cost 30 bucks a piece on Amazon. They record videos with their free hands. "How can we be free if we still can't do something just because we want to. What kind of freedom is that?" After a minute of dripping wax straight onto my hand and almost burning my phone cover, I end up breaking my candle in half.

"Women should have the right to prove themselves. But having to prove themselves over and over, again and again – they die before they get to stop. Today, this has happened to a doctor. She worked 12-14 hours a day for what? Just to save lives, yet her own life was put to an end." The man with the backpack is puttering around behind me trying to find a candle that stays alight. I steal one from him and blend back into the crowd.

As Anita begins to wrap up – having given the discourse an edge by immediately establishing that women's 'liberation' today is nominal & localised to urban areas – she stresses the importance of women standing together, pointing out how often it is that even within feminine – if not feminist – circles, the burden of proof is placed upon victims. Just as she starts to move the conversation toward a dialogue on internalised misogyny and victim shaming, though, one of the upper-class women in the front row begins applauding her. "Very good." She says, approvingly. "Very good, yes, women should support women."

Anita pauses for a beat, then recovers, again beginning to complete her thought. But the old woman interrupts again, concluding her sentence for her, and punctuating the end of the speech with more clapping. The crowd joins in with finality, and Anita returns to her place. Two women beside me begin whispering in Bengali, asking each other how long they plan on staying. "I'm going to leave in five minutes," says one.

The other replies. "Me too."

“The water supply pump to the basti goes under the B2 block at Vasant Kunj. Some defect in the pipe had led to extremely bad quality water being supplied. Members of RWA in B2 are preventing the pipes from being fixed. The reason? The machine will spoil the grass in the newly constructed park. Aesthetics of the few over basic human needs of the masses. Protests are ongoing (sic)” - 8th August 2024, Facebook, Sangrami Gharelu Kamgaar Union^[2].

In March 2023, Samdhish Bhatia filmed a video^[3] in Vasant Vihar’s Kusumpur Pahadi, a slum locality that has now become Indian Journalism’s flagbearer for Delhi’s urban water crisis, incidentally an issue that was also covered in Anuska Chatterjee and Stuti Paul Singh’s article^[4] for Feminism in India back in February this year, the same publication for which this story was initially written. But Kusumpur Pahadi’s story is hardly a novel one, recreated over and over again in Harijan Bastis and Jai Bhim Nagars and the countless spaces of new age apartheid that define India’s urban reality.

In recent years, with the intervention of political activism groups like Collective and the unionisation of the female workforce - the main breadwinners of the family; mostly Bengali domestic workers - mobilisation within the Bastis has gained momentum. The library Kalpana was referring to is a result of this mobilisation; a students’ space in the Harijan Basti next to Imperial Clubs and premium gyms. Yet, in all these years, and even with the ongoing water conflict, last week’s protest at VSM was the first ever to witness participation from the RWA - a participation, lest one forgets, that was accompanied by a denial of formal permissions, and strictly individualised.

So it is unsurprising that as the conversations begin to drag on, and as the sans-mic stage is slowly and quietly wrestled away from the protesters that initiated, organised, and made up the majority of the protest to those that prevented it from happening in front of my eyes, that the tension gets stronger.

The speeches begin to meld together, and the testimonies turn into rants. A woman from the RWA group turns to the circle and implores all women to hold men accountable at all stages of violence, directly addressing the domestic workers.

“Rape is not the first thing a rapist does,” she says, repeating a rhetoric that’s already been made several times over by several different women in several different speeches that have said the same thing. “You have to stop them at the first step. When someone touches you in the bus, publicly shame him! I have done it. I did when I was in my 20s! It discourages them from doing more.” A few more women shuffle off from the Union side. They have work tomorrow.

The advice turns into an argument within the RWA group as the speech is followed by another that reiterates, yet again, that the responsibility is not all ours. I wonder if the conversation has moved forward a single step from where Anita's speech left off, and don't bother wondering too hard. I stop recording the speeches and start taking notes on who speaks and for how long. A total of 15 speeches are delivered by the end of the hour, not counting cross-conversation – only four by domestic workers, and not one of them uninterrupted.

When a woman standing beside Anita tries to discuss how this protest is a good start, but we need to keep up this momentum when the same thing happens to a daughter from a poor household like hers, the B2 block women standing opposite her plead to the group that no, "it's about *all* women. *All* of our daughters deserve to be safe." Fifteen minutes later when the same thing is said by a woman in jeans and a short Kurti, citing the rape of a 6-year-old in UP¹⁵¹, the group bursts with applause.

It's a terrible thing to say, but I'm bored. When the discussion isn't infuriating, it's shameful. In a conversation over tea & *bidis* a few days later, Collective Delhi's head and PhD scholar Sourya would tell me, "If anything, the conversation has gone backward from where it was during Nirbhaya. Institutional policy was upfront, and the critique of rape culture was a lot more scathing." The speeches at the protest seem intent on illustrating his point.

Two women beside me are having a sidebar, one of whom is named Rehaya. As yet another RWA woman goes on about shaming Eve teasers as a rape-preventing strategy, I join in. From the centre of the semicircle, a domestic worker who has been vocal from the start shares an incident where she and her family beat up a guy harassing their daughter on their street. "Ma'am, this happened to us once. We beat him up, we beat him up good," she says. "Very good, you did well." The RWA members approve.

Rehaya, personally, does not share my derision - of course, according to Shreya & Arundhati, neither do the majority of the union or its activists - or that of the women around who are planning their escapes. Her only contention is that for all the talk of all women standing for all others, all women hardly stand against all men.

"These boys are also someone's sons, aren't they? When their sons do something, do they support the girl? Of course not, they don't even believe her. They think their sons can do no wrong." Someone from the other end says that violence isn't the answer.

And so it goes.

9:45 | Dispersal

Another 15 minutes of talking later, Shreya asks us all to hold hands and form a chain. The clusters appear again, divided cleanly by Kho-Kho poles of people holding posters standing in between, such that no one has to touch anyone they don't want to. A few days later when I tell Shreya about this story to try to score some interviews she is less than elated. She shares with me her apprehensions about comparing a comfortable inter-class protest with an incident as 'extreme' as Hiranandani's, which are understandable. I explain to her that the comparison is not one of degree, but of foundation, which helps but does not satisfy her. She defends the B2 residents with all her might. "They were only speaking because we asked them to speak. What happened here was completely different. Some of the B2 women even held hands with their maids," She says, like it helps her case. "The women were really happy."

What I remember, though, is that Rehaia didn't mind holding mine. Even with all my sweating.



(Photographs via Collective, by Akshay)

The candles and posters were left in the middle, like some kind of remembrance. Facing the road repeating slogans after Shreya alongside 50 other women, I felt sad how loud I could hear the sound of my own voice.

I wish I could tell you the night was the triumph it was made out to be. I wish I could write the article Shreya & Anubhuti would want me to. Class and caste uniting for women; an intersectional battle against patriarchy & sexual violence. But it wasn't.

Everytime a woman from the union tried to bring up – & doesn't it sound like a dirty, dirty word – politics of any kind, she was shut down by someone from the RWA explaining to her how this was not the place, or the time. "It's not about her being a doctor," a woman from my side of the semicircle had begun after a neighbourhood doctor had come over to personally announce the national IMA strike, only to be unceremoniously cut off by the old woman from earlier, saying, "but you have to consider what happened afterwards, you have to consider what they did to her," and so it went.

In the end, the night was left unclaimed. By ten o'clock everyone had made nice and left, leaving a mess of wax and paper behind. No Shelter for Sandip Ghosh. End Rape Culture. Freedom from Patriarchy. Rise Above Caste and Communal Violence. Safety for ALL Working Women. A little pile of white and black in the middle of the sidewalk. The chit that read 'Say' was lost among them.

The auto driver had asked me what that pile was when the crowd in front of it had gone. "It was for a protest against what happened in Kolkata," I told him. "Oh," was all he said back, and as we left, I thought of whoever next morning would have to sweep it all away.

I was glad it wasn't me.



(PHOTOGRAPH VIA SGU, BY ANANDITA)



(Photographs via Collective, by Akshay)

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Akshay is a law student who has been working with COLLECTIVE organizations for the last 4-5 years. They run a library by the name of Sabki Library in Vasant Kunj (referenced in the article) where they work to educate the children of slum areas. They also run a marathon group by the name of Vasant Kunj Runners.

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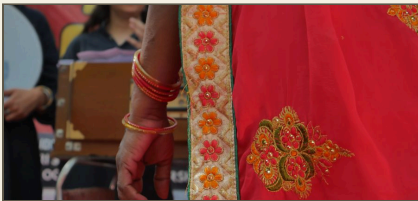
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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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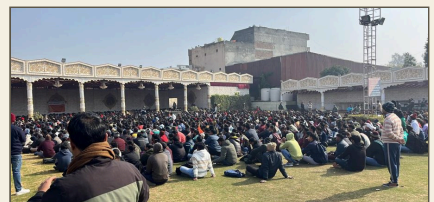
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^[1] John Mulaney's set

^[2] Sangrami Gharelu Kamgaar Union

^[3] video

^[4] article

^[5] 6-year-old in UP